

A PLANNING & COORDINATION WORKBOOK

Aging Parent Home Transition System

A practical workbook for adult children helping a parent
downsize, move, or prepare for a safer next home.

Conversation scripts • Room-by-room triage • Sibling coordination
Move timeline • Donation & sell tracking • First 30 days

How to Use This System

Use this workbook when a parent may need to move, downsize, clear a home, or prepare for a simpler living situation — but the process feels stuck.

The goal is not to force a decision in one conversation. The goal is to make the next step visible, reduce family confusion, and turn a vague emotional project into a series of practical decisions.

For best results

- Start with the Conversation Module before touching belongings.
- Choose one room for the first inventory pass.
- Assign sibling and family roles early, even if the first assignments are small.
- Track decisions in writing so the same arguments do not repeat.
- Keep medical, legal, tax, and sale decisions with qualified professionals.

Please note

This is a planning and coordination workbook. It does not provide legal, tax, financial, medical, or real-estate advice. For those decisions, consult a qualified professional.

Start Here: Which Path Are You On?

Use this page before starting the full workbook. Find the situation that matches yours and begin there. You can change paths as things shift.

Path A: Urgent Trigger

Choose this path if there has been a fall, an unsafe-driving concern, repeated missed household tasks, a sudden health change, a housing deadline, or another time-sensitive event.

First steps:

- Do not start by sorting the whole house.
- Identify the immediate safety or logistics issue.
- Choose the smallest decision that reduces risk this week.
- Assign one family coordinator.
- Use the Move Logistics Timeline and First 30 Days sections early.

Path B: Declining Upkeep, No Immediate Deadline

Choose this path if the home is becoming too much to maintain, but there is no fixed move date.

First steps:

- Use the Conversation Module to open the topic gently.
- Pick one low-emotion room for a first pass.
- Use the Room Inventory Sheet.
- Create the Sibling Coordination Board before the project grows.
- Revisit the plan weekly.

Path C: Parent Fully Resistant

Choose this path if your parent shuts down, argues, or says the family is trying to take control.

First steps:

- Do not begin with boxes, moving dates, or selling the house.
- Use only one conversation script.
- Ask what your parent wants to control.
- Look for one small planning agreement, such as naming must-keep items.
- Wait before attempting a full inventory.

Path D: Family Conflict Is the Main Blocker

Choose this path if siblings or relatives disagree about timing, roles, money, belongings, or how much help each person should provide.

First steps:

- Use the Sibling Coordination Board before another debate.
- Separate feelings, facts, and tasks.
- Assign work based on availability, not guilt.
- Put disputed items in the High-Emotion Parking Lot.
- Send one weekly family update so decisions are visible.

Worked Example: What a First Pass Looks Like

Use this example as a model. A good first pass is practical, imperfect, and limited.

Scenario: Denise is helping her 78-year-old mother consider a move from a three-bedroom house into a smaller apartment. Her mother is not ready to discuss selling the house, but she agreed to sort the linen closet for 30 minutes.

Example: Room Inventory Sheet

Room: Linen closet **Date:** April 12 **People present:** Denise, Mom

Item or group	Category	Notes	Owner of next action	Deadline
Two unopened sheet sets	Gift to family	Mom wants granddaughter Maya to have them	Denise texts Maya	Apr 15
Worn towels	Donate	Usable but not needed	Brother drops at animal shelter	Apr 20
Old electric blanket	Professional review	Cord looks worn; do not use	Ask disposal site re: safe disposal	Apr 18
Guest towels	Keep for next home	Limit to one small stack	Mom chooses favorites	Today
Holiday table linens	Decide later	Too emotional today	Move to Parking Lot	Revisit May 1

Example: Sibling Coordination Board

Task	Category	Owner	Status	Due	Blocker
Ask Maya about sheet sets	Gift	Denise	In progress	Apr 15	Waiting on reply
Check shelter towel policy	Donate	Rob	Not started	Apr 18	None
Research blanket disposal	Discard	Denise	Not started	Apr 18	Need city website
Start must-keep linen list	Inventory	Mom + Denise	In progress	Apr 20	Mom wants time

Why this works:

The family started with a low-emotion area. Hard items were not forced. Each action has an owner and a date. The parent kept control over favorites. The project moved forward without requiring a full move decision.

Module 1 — The Conversation Module

Purpose: Help you raise the topic without making your parent feel ambushed, judged, or pushed out of their home.

Before You Bring It Up

Complete this privately before the first conversation.

Prompt	Your notes
What specific concern made this conversation necessary now?	
Is the concern safety, maintenance, money, loneliness, distance from help, or family capacity?	
What does your parent likely fear losing?	
What does your parent still want control over?	
What outcome would be a reasonable first step, short of a full move?	
Who should not be in the first conversation because they escalate tension?	

Conversation Starter Scripts

Use the version that best matches your situation. Edit the words so they sound like you.

If your parent says “I’m not ready”

“I hear you. I’m not asking you to decide everything today. I’d like us to make a simple plan so that if something changes, we are not making rushed decisions under stress. Could we start by looking at which parts of the house feel hardest to keep up with?”

Follow-up questions:

- What would make this home easier for you over the next year?
- Which rooms or tasks feel like the most work now?
- If you ever chose to move, what would you want to bring with you no matter what?

If your parent says “You just want me out”

“That is not what I want. I want you to have as much choice as possible. Waiting until there is an emergency gives everyone fewer choices. I would rather talk while you can still tell us what matters to you.”

Follow-up questions:

- What would make you feel respected in this process?
- What decisions do you want to make yourself?
- What decisions would you want help with?

If your parent refuses to sort anything

"We do not have to sort the whole house. Could we choose one low-stakes area, like a linen closet or a drawer, and use that as a test? If it feels awful, we stop and rethink the approach."

Follow-up questions:

- Which area feels easiest to start with?
- Are there items you already know you want family members to have?
- Would it help if we only sorted for 30 minutes?

If siblings disagree

"Before we debate the whole plan, can we agree on the next useful step? We can separate decisions into urgent, soon, and later so we are not fighting about everything at once."

Follow-up questions:

- What are we each worried will happen if we wait?
- What are we each worried will happen if we move too fast?
- Who is actually available to do work in the next two weeks?

Parent Preference Snapshot

Use this after the first or second conversation.

Preference	Parent's answer
Ideal living situation	
Places they would consider	
Places they refuse to consider	
Must-keep belongings	
Belongings they want family to receive	
Biggest fear about moving or downsizing	
Biggest relief they hope for	
Decisions they want control over	
People they trust in the process	

Conversation Debrief

Complete this after each major conversation.

Question	Notes
What went better than expected?	
What triggered resistance?	
What did your parent agree to, even slightly?	
What topic should wait?	
What is the next small action?	
Who owns that action?	

Question	Notes
Due date	

Module 2 — Room-by-Room Inventory & Triage

Purpose: Turn “the whole house” into smaller decisions.

Triage Categories

Use these categories consistently.

Category	Meaning
Keep for next home	Parent wants it and it realistically fits the next living situation
Gift to family	Parent wants a specific person to have it
Sell	Item may have resale value and someone is assigned to sell it
Donate	Useful item that can leave without sale effort
Discard / recycle	Broken, unsafe, expired, or not worth moving
Decide later	Emotionally hard or unclear; revisit once per week
Professional review	Needs expert input, appraisal, legal review, or safety handling

First-Pass Rule

The first pass is not for perfect decisions. It is for reducing overwhelm.

During the first pass:

- Do not open every box in a room.
- Do not argue over sentimental items for more than five minutes.
- Do not start with photos, paperwork, jewelry, or family heirlooms.
- Do start with visible surfaces, duplicates, expired items, linens, garage items, pantry items, and everyday household goods.

Room Inventory Sheet

Room: _____ **Date:** _____ **People present:** _____

Item or group	Category	Notes	Owner of next action	Deadline

Room Summary

Question	Answer
What can leave this week?	
What needs a family decision?	
What needs a professional opinion?	
What should not be touched yet?	
What is the next room or area?	

The High-Emotion Parking Lot Method

Purpose: Keep one object from derailing the whole project.

Some items are not hard because they are useful. They are hard because they carry grief, identity, family history, guilt, or disagreement. When one item starts a fight or shuts the process down, do not force the decision in the moment. Move it to the High-Emotion Parking Lot and keep working somewhere else.

The rule

If one item takes more than five minutes of argument or silence, park it.

Parking an item does not mean discarding it. It means the family is choosing progress over getting stuck.

Use this list when an item creates conflict or shuts down progress.

Item	Why it is hard	Temporary location	Revisit date	Decision owner

Module 3 — The Sibling Coordination Board

Purpose: Make invisible labor visible and prevent one person from becoming the default project manager.

Family Roles

Assign roles based on availability and strengths, not guilt.

Role	Person	Backup	Notes
Parent conversation lead			
Inventory coordinator			
Donation / drop-off lead			
Sale / resale lead			
Paperwork gatherer			
Move logistics lead			
New-home setup lead			
Family update sender			

Task Board

Task	Category	Owner	Status	Due	Blocker

Category options: Conversation • Inventory • Donate • Sell • Move • Setup • Paperwork

Status options: Not started • In progress • Waiting • Done

Weekly Family Update Template

Subject: Parent Home Transition Update — Week of [date]

What changed this week:

—

Decisions needed:

—

Tasks assigned:

[Name]: [task] by [date]

Blocked items:

—
Next focus:
—

Conflict Reset Script

Use this when the family conversation turns into blame.

"We may not agree on the whole plan, but we need a way to make the next decision. Let's separate feelings, facts, and tasks. The feeling is valid. The fact is what must be handled. The task is who will do the next step."

Feeling	Fact	Next task	Owner

Module 4 — Move Logistics Timeline

Purpose: Give the family a countdown even if the final move date is not fixed yet.

8-Week Countdown

Use this as a flexible planning map. If your timeline is shorter, combine weeks. If it is longer, stretch the early weeks.

When	Focus	Tasks
Week 8	Define the target	Confirm likely move window; choose first three rooms to inventory; list professionals to contact if needed
Week 7	Start low-emotion sorting	Complete first-pass triage in one easy room; start donation list; identify obvious discards
Week 6	Family assignments	Assign roles; create task board; start weekly update; identify items family members want
Week 5	Paperwork & practical details	Gather key household documents, warranties, manuals, contact lists, utility details
Week 4	Sell / donate / discard flow	Schedule donation pickups and drop-offs; list sale items; set deadlines for undecided items
Week 3	New-home planning	Measure important furniture; plan essential first-week items; choose what must be accessible on day one
Week 2	Pack & confirm logistics	Confirm movers or helpers; pack non-essentials; label boxes by destination and priority
Week 1	Final readiness	Pack essentials; confirm keys and access; prepare first-night box; send family update

First-Night Box

Pack this separately and keep it easy to reach.

Item	Packed?	Notes
Basic toiletries		
Change of clothes		
Phone charger		
Important contacts		
Note showing where medication information is kept		Planning only; confirm medication handling with the appropriate professional
Favorite mug or cup		
Bedding		
Towels		

Item	Packed?	Notes
Snacks and water		
Remote controls / essential electronics		
Basic tools		
Important documents folder		

Move-Day Contact Sheet

Contact	Name	Phone / email	Notes
Parent			
Primary family coordinator			
Backup family contact			
Mover / helper			
Building / new-home contact			
Donation pickup			
Utility contact			

Module 5 — Donation & Sell Tracker

Purpose: Prevent piles from becoming permanent and keep decisions traceable.

Important

This tracker helps organize information. It is not tax advice. Ask a qualified professional about donation values, deductions, appraisals, and records.

Donate Tracker

Item / group	Condition	Donation location	Drop-off / pickup	Receipt?	Notes

Sell Tracker

Item	Asking price	Platform / place	Owner	Listed	Deadline	Outcome

Outcome options: Sold • Donated • Kept • Discarded

Family Gift Tracker

Use this to reduce confusion about who asked for what.

Item	Intended person	Parent approved?	Pickup / shipping plan	Completed?

Deadline Rule

For each sell, donate, or gift item, set a date. If the action is not completed by that date, choose a fallback.

Item	Original plan	Deadline	Fallback if not done

Item	Original plan	Deadline	Fallback if not done

Module 6 — First 30 Days After the Move

Purpose: Help your parent settle in after the boxes are moved — when the family often assumes the hard part is over.

Week 1 — Basic Comfort

Task	Owner	Done
Confirm bed, bathroom, lighting, and walking paths are usable		
Put daily-use items in obvious places		
Set up phone, chargers, remotes, and TV basics		
Place important contacts somewhere visible		
Confirm trash, recycling, and mail routines		
Identify missing essentials		

Week 2 — Routines

Task	Owner	Done
Confirm grocery and meal routine		
Confirm transportation routine		
Update family on what still feels hard		
Decide what remaining boxes can wait		
Schedule one low-pressure social or familiar activity		

Week 3 — Belongings & Layout

Task	Owner	Done
Review items that still do not have a place		
Adjust furniture or layout if daily use feels awkward		
Revisit high-emotion items from the parking lot		
Remove empty boxes and packing materials		

Week 4 — Stabilize

Task	Owner	Done
Make a short list of what is working		
Make a short list of what still feels unsettled		
Decide what support is needed next month		

Task	Owner	Done
Send family update with remaining tasks		

30-Day Debrief

Question	Notes
What does your parent like better than expected?	
What still feels hard?	
What family tasks remain?	
What needs outside help?	
What can be considered complete?	

Quick-Start Version

If everything feels urgent, do only these five steps first:

1. Use one conversation script from Module 1.
2. Pick one easy room.
3. Complete one Room Inventory Sheet.
4. Assign three family tasks.
5. Set one donation or sell deadline.

Bonus: One-Page Parent Downsizing Plan

Keep this page where the whole family can see it. It is the project on a single sheet.

Field	Notes
Parent's current home concern	
Desired next living situation	
First room to sort	
Biggest emotional blocker	
Biggest logistical blocker	
Family coordinator	
Next conversation date	
First donation / sell deadline	
Likely move window	
First 30-days-after focus	

Suggested Folder Setup

If you turn this workbook into a digital folder, this structure keeps everything findable:

- 01 Conversation Notes
- 02 Room Inventories
- 03 Family Task Board
- 04 Move Timeline
- 05 Donate / Sell / Gift Tracker
- 06 First 30 Days
- 07 Professional Documents

A closing note

This process is rarely only about stuff. It is about control, memory, safety, family roles, and the fear of change. You do not need to solve all of that at once.

Start small. Write decisions down. Keep the next step visible.